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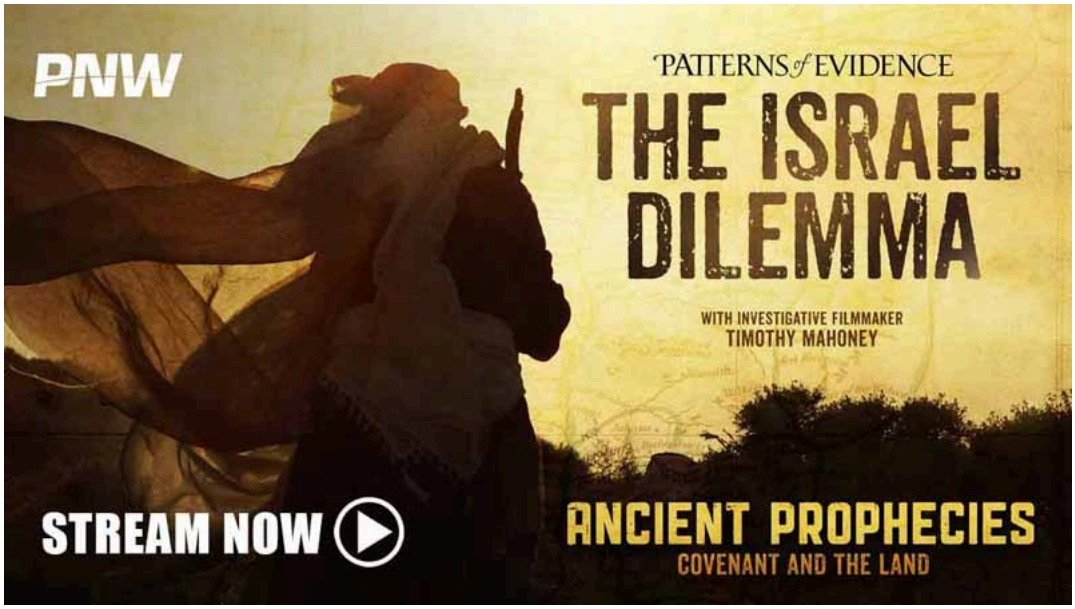

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ARTICLE

When The Bible Becomes 'Hate Speech': A Wake Up Call For Christians

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BY PNW STAFF MARCH 28, 2026

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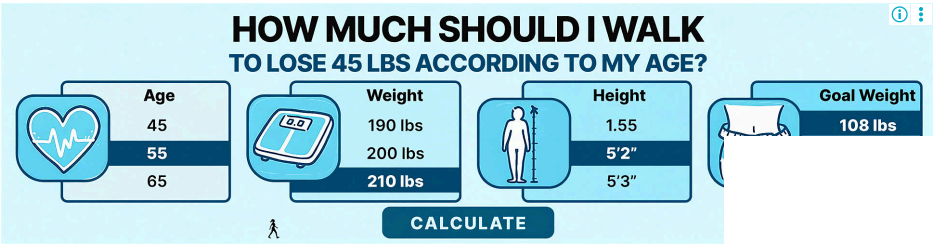
There are moments in a nation's history when a law reveals far more than legal intent. It exposes the moral direction of a country. This week may prove to be one of those moments for Canada.

The passage of Bill C-9 through the House of Commons is not just another legislative development buried in the churn of parliamentary procedure. It is a flashing warning sign. For many Christians across Canada, it feels like something deeper is being put on trial -- not merely "hate," as the bill is framed, but biblical conviction itself.

Canadian MPs passed Bill C-9, the so-called "Combatting Hate Act," in a 186-137 vote, sending it to the Senate after fierce opposition from Conservatives, the NDP, and the Green Party. Critics say the legislation removes long-standing safeguards that protected religious expression, particularly the ability to discuss or quote Scripture in good faith on contested moral issues.

Even the Canadian Conference of Catholic Bishops warned that removing the religious-text defense could create a "chilling effect" on clergy, educators, and believers who fear traditional biblical teaching could be interpreted as hate.

And that is exactly the concern.



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Because once a government begins to treat historic Christian teaching as socially harmful by default, the path ahead becomes disturbingly clear.

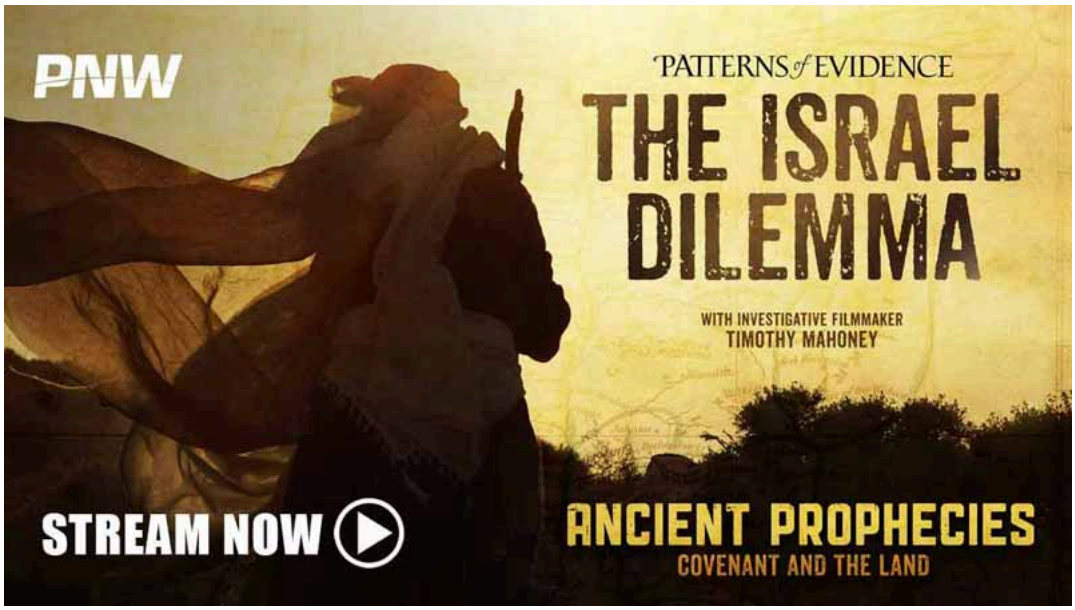
What happens when a pastor preaches from Romans 1? What happens when a Christian school teaches that marriage is between one man and one woman? What happens when a youth leader tells a confused teenager that God created humanity male and female? What happens when a parent, counselor, or Christian teacher takes a biblical stand on sexuality or gender in a culture that increasingly considers such views beyond the pale?

For generations, those beliefs were not considered radical. They were mainstream Christian doctrine. Today, they are being recast as suspicious, intolerant, or even dangerous.

That is the real issue with bills like this. They often arrive wearing the language of compassion, safety, and public order. But once written into law, they can become tools for selective punishment. The text of a law may speak in broad terms, but its enforcement is often shaped by ideology, bureaucracy, activist pressure, and the political mood of the moment. Christians do not need to imagine a future where biblical speech is stigmatized -- they are already living in the early stages of it.

And no, this does not mean every sermon will suddenly become a criminal case. That would be too simplistic. The greater threat may be subtler and, in some ways, more effective: self-censorship.

That is how freedom often dies in modern democracies -- not first with prison cells, but with silence.



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Silence from churches afraid of complaints. Silence from Christian teachers afraid of losing jobs. Silence from parents afraid of school boards. Silence from ministries afraid of being investigated, deplatformed, defunded, or dragged through expensive legal battles. When the state creates enough ambiguity around what can be said, many people stop saying anything at all.

And if Christians can no longer freely proclaim what Scripture teaches about sin, repentance, identity, marriage, and salvation, then the Gospel itself begins to be fenced in by the state.

That is not a small matter.

Christianity is not merely a private spirituality built around vague kindness. It is a truth claim. It declares that Jesus Christ is Lord, that all people are called to repent, and that God -- not government, not culture, not popular consensus -- defines what is good, holy, and true. That means Christianity will inevitably collide with any political system that demands moral conformity to state-approved beliefs.

And that collision now appears to be intensifying in Canada.

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Because once believers begin softening the Bible to remain legally comfortable, they are no longer defending religious liberty -- they are negotiating away truth.

There is also a broader national cost here. A society that criminalizes or suppresses deeply held religious conviction is not becoming more tolerant. It is simply replacing one moral framework with another and using state power to enforce it. That is not pluralism. That is coercion dressed in modern language.

A free nation must allow its citizens to say things the ruling class finds offensive, especially when those beliefs are rooted in centuries-old religious tradition and expressed without violence or malice. If Canada loses that principle, Christians will not be the only ones eventually affected. Once governments gain the power to police moral speech, the circle of forbidden opinion rarely stays small.

Today it may be biblical teaching on marriage and gender.

Tomorrow it may be something else entirely.

This is why so many believers are not merely disappointed by Bill C-9 -- they are deeply troubled by what it represents. It is not just a policy disagreement. It is another signal that biblical Christianity is increasingly being treated not as a protected faith, but as a problem to be managed.

And Christians should not ignore that.

The bill now heads to Canada's rubber-stamp Senate for review -- a chamber filled largely with unelected, Liberal-appointed senators who hold immense power without ever facing voters, making the outcome feel all but predetermined.

The question now is whether the church will bend with that pressure -- or stand.

Because a Gospel that cannot speak clearly is not being protected.

It is being contained.

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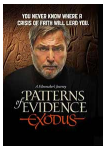

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